

# The New China

The first half of the 20th century was a period of turmoil for China. The country went through revolutions and civil wars, suffered a foreign invasion, and took part in two world wars. Finally, after decades of conflict that had caused serious hardship and division, a new communist China emerged in 1949.

After the fall of the Qing in 1911 (see pp.140–141), China was thrown into a period of conflict between competing factions known as the Warlord Era. This lasted from 1916 to 1928, when the Nationalist Party reunified China. Soon after, a long struggle for power began between the Nationalists and the Chinese Communist Party (CCP).

In 1931, Japan invaded China. The Sino-Japanese War that followed became part of the wider conflict of World War II, which started in 1939. China joined the Allies, and the war ended with the defeat of Japan in

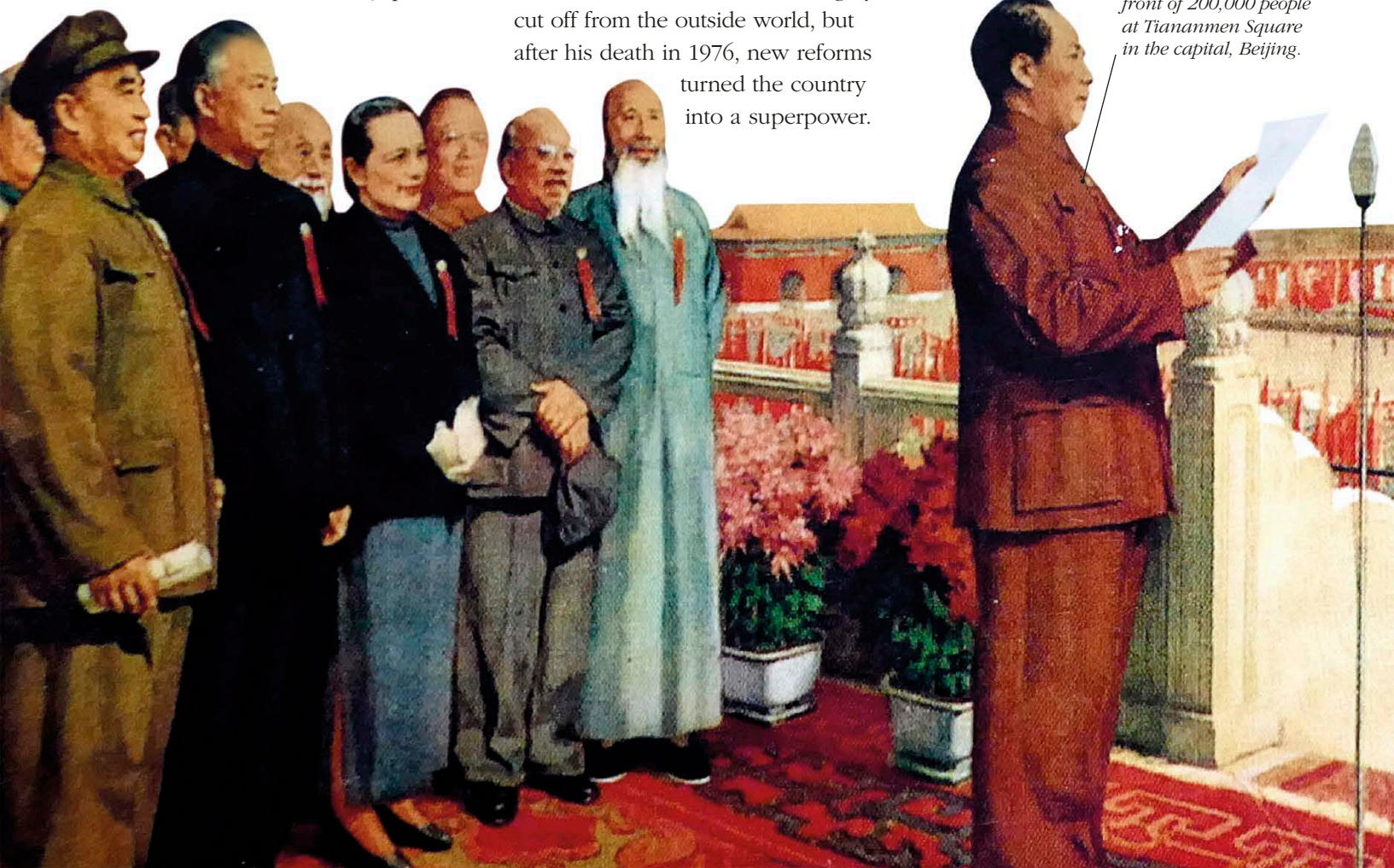
1945 (see pp.194–195). The fighting between the CCP and the Nationalists, which had halted due to the war, resumed the following year. The CCP won and established their government in 1949.

This new China was led by Mao Zedong, who launched a series of campaigns to reform the economy and society along communist lines. In 1966, he began the Cultural Revolution, an attempt to get rid of old attitudes by advancing communist ideals and solidifying Mao's power. During Mao's rule, China was unstable and largely cut off from the outside world, but after his death in 1976, new reforms turned the country into a superpower.



## ▲ XINHAI REVOLUTION

*In October 1911, revolutionaries overthrew the Qing Dynasty and set up the Republic of China the following year. Revolutionary leader Sun Yat-sen (above) became the first president, but he was soon replaced by the military official Yuan Shikai.*



*Mao Zedong declares his new government in front of 200,000 people at Tiananmen Square in the capital, Beijing.*